Case: Sophie Chen — Selecting Podcasts for a Wellness Brand Campaign

1. The person and the decision

> **Enough:** a specific person and one decision your app is for, so that a reader who has never seen your project can picture it.

Sophie Chen is an Influencer Partnerships Manager at a public relations agency representing a wellness brand preparing to launch a new product in early 2027. She needs to decide which health and wellness podcasts to prioritize for potential guest appearances by the brand's founder. Her goal is to identify relevant, actively publishing podcasts that could help the brand reach its target audience. Choosing poorly could waste the team's outreach time and marketing resources on inactive or unsuitable shows.

2. Their real situation and alternatives

> **Enough:** how this kind of person makes this decision today, what they are trying to achieve and what matters to them, and the alternatives they have to your app, from at least two sources you read.

As an Influencer Partnerships Manager, Sophie needs to identify podcasts that align with her client's wellness brand and target audience. According to Curzon PR's How to Pitch to Podcasts, PR professionals should research a podcast's content, audience, format, and previous guests before reaching out. For Sophie, this means finding health and wellness podcasts that are actively publishing, feature guest interviews, and reach listeners who may be interested in the brand. Selecting unsuitable podcasts could waste outreach time and reduce the effectiveness of the campaign.

Without our app, Sophie could use podcast discovery tools such as Listen Notes to search for relevant shows and review their recent episodes. She could also use Rephonic to investigate listener demographics, estimated audience size, and previous guests before making outreach decisions. However, our app's podcast metadata alone cannot confirm audience demographics, actual listener engagement, or whether a show accepts guest appearances. Therefore, Sophie would use our app for initial discovery and shortlisting, then verify promising candidates through other research tools and direct contact with podcast hosts.

Sources:

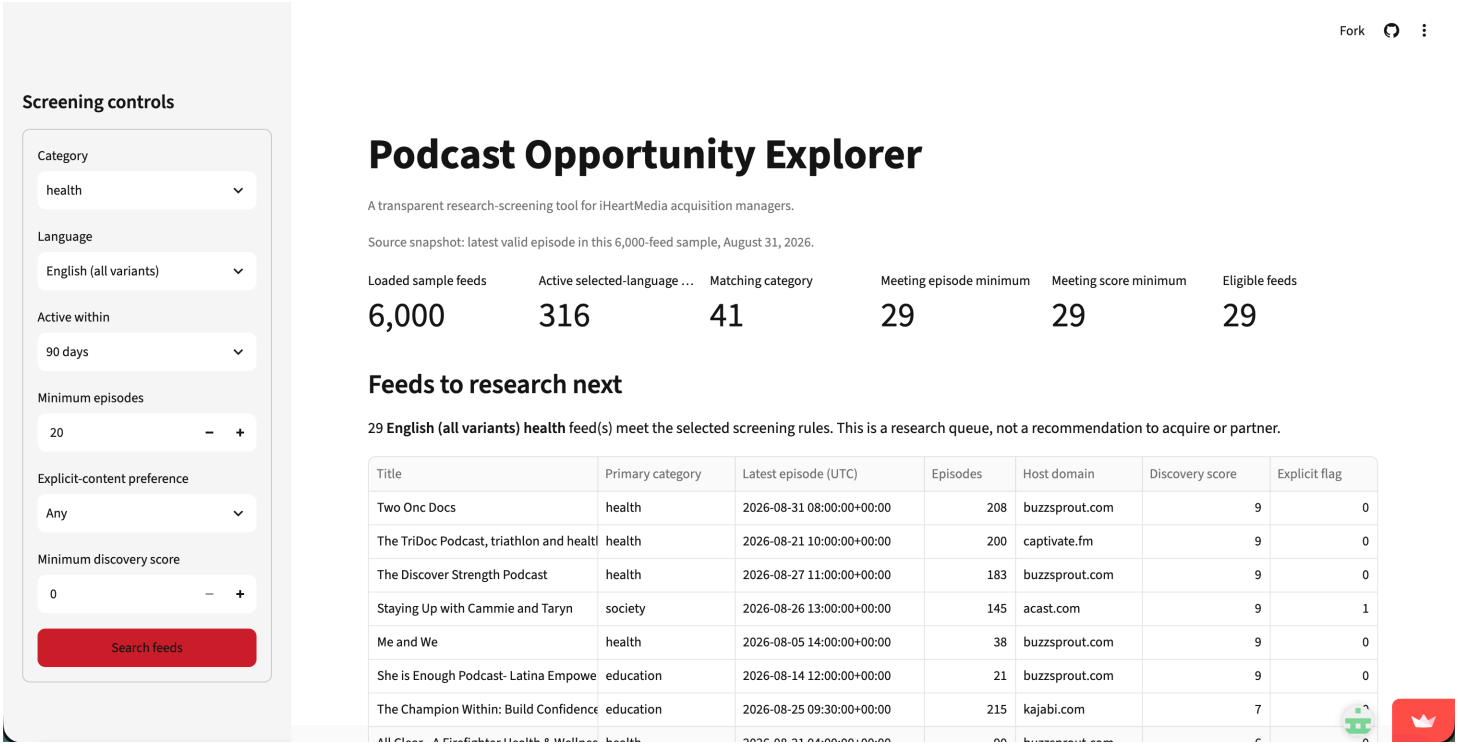
- Curzon PR — How to Pitch to Podcasts: A Playbook for PRs https://curzonpr.com/theprinsider/how-to-pitch-to-podcasts-a-playbook-for-pr-firms/
- Rephonic — Why PR Teams Use Rephonic's Podcast Search Tool https://rephonic.com/blog/podcast-search-tool/

3. The app in use

> **Enough:** your team's live link, what the person selects, at least one screenshot **of the live app** with the selections visible, and what they see, in your own words.

Live link: (https://dso576-project-podcast-index.streamlit.app/)

What they select:
Sophie uses the Podcast Opportunity Explorer to identify potential podcasts for her client's wellness brand. She applies the following screening criteria:
Category: health
Language: English (all variants)
Active within: 90 days
Minimum episodes: 20
Explicit-content preference: Any
Minimum discovery score: 0



What they see:
The app searches a sample of 6,000 podcast feeds, of which 316 meet the selected language and activity criteria. Among these, 41 match the health category, and 29 meet the remaining screening requirements.
These 29 eligible feeds provide Sophie with a manageable initial research shortlist. She can investigate their content and publishing activity before deciding which podcasts to contact. However, eligibility does not guarantee that a podcast has the right audience or is willing to host guest appearances.

4. Reading the result for their decision

> **Enough:** an answer to each question below, each backed by evidence: a number from the data, a rule, a source, or a check you ran.

Does the number measure what this person cares about?
Partially. The app identifies 29 eligible health-related podcast feeds from a sample of 6,000, helping Sophie narrow down potential candidates for guest appearances. However, the number measures feeds that meet the selected screening criteria, not necessarily podcasts suitable for her client's campaign. The app does not provide audience demographics, listener engagement, or guest availability. Therefore, the 29 eligible feeds are useful as an initial research shortlist rather than a direct measure of partnership suitability. This is an example of Kind 3: The real thing or a stand-in, because screening eligibility is only a proxy for potential partnership opportunities.

Who is in the rows, and who is not?
The app uses a 6,000-feed sample rather than the entire podcast market. With the selected filters, 316 feeds meet the language and activity criteria, 41 match the health category, and 29 meet all screening requirements, including at least 20 episodes. The activity window is measured relative to the dataset's latest valid timestamp (August 31, 2026), rather than today's date.
Podcasts outside the sample, shows that do not meet the selected language, category, activity, or episode requirements, and potentially suitable podcasts with fewer than 20 episodes are excluded. In addition, each row represents a crawled podcast feed rather than necessarily a unique show. The app deduplicates repeated nonblank Podcast GUIDs, but feeds with blank GUIDs cannot be reliably deduplicated. Therefore, the 29 eligible feeds should not be interpreted as the total number of suitable podcasts in the market.

What outside the data matters to this decision?
Several factors beyond the app's data could influence Sophie's decision. First, she needs to understand each podcast's audience demographics and interests to determine whether its listeners

align with her client's target market. Second, she must verify whether the podcast features or accepts external guests and whether the brand's founder would be a suitable interviewee. Finally, partnership costs and scheduling availability may affect whether a podcast fits the campaign's budget and product launch timeline. Sophie would need additional research through tools such as Rephonic, podcast websites, and direct communication with hosts before deciding which podcasts to contact. A dataset check also confirmed that the 6,000-row sample contains no guest metadata, episode-level descriptions, or transcripts. Although 5,470 feeds have show descriptions, these cannot reliably establish whether a podcast accepts guest interviews.

What could they wrongly conclude from it?
Sophie might mistakenly assume that the 29 eligible feeds are all suitable guest appearance opportunities, or that podcasts with higher discovery scores are better partnership candidates. However, the discovery score is a Podcast Index discovery signal, not a measure of audience size, downloads, revenue, or partnership suitability. A podcast with a high discovery score may still have an unsuitable audience or may not accept external guests.
The app already addresses some of these risks in its "Definitions and limits" section, which explains the meaning of the discovery score, the dataset's coverage, and the need for additional research before making partnership decisions. Sophie should therefore use the results for initial screening rather than as a final partnership recommendation.

5. The verdict: prove or break

> **Enough:** whether this person is better off with the app than with the alternatives in part 2, the app's place among them, and what they must not use it for. Then **either** compelling evidence that, for this person, the app is as good as it gets with the data available, **or** a change request that makes it better for this case without being made only for this case or making other users' answers worse.

Verdict: Prove — the app is useful for initial podcast discovery and screening, but not for making final partnership decisions.
Sophie is better off using the Podcast Opportunity Explorer as an initial screening tool because it narrows a sample of 6,000 podcast feeds to 29 eligible health-related feeds based on category, language, publishing activity, and episode count. Compared with manually searching podcast directories such as Listen Notes, the app provides a structured way to create a manageable research shortlist. However, tools such as Rephonic remain important for evaluating audience demographics and potential partnership suitability.
Sophie should not use the results alone to decide which podcasts to contact or partner with. The app does not provide audience demographics, listener engagement, or guest availability. Its "Definitions

and limits" section clearly explains that the discovery score does not represent audience size, downloads, revenue, or partnership value. It also states that the data come from a 6,000-feed sample and that publishing activity is measured relative to August 31, 2026, rather than the current date. These warnings help users interpret the results appropriately.

I also checked whether the dataset could support a guest-interview indicator. The 6,000-row sample contains no guest metadata, episode-level descriptions, or transcripts. Although 5,470 feeds have show descriptions, using keyword matching to infer guest appearances would be unreliable and could produce false positives or negatives. A dependable guest-interview indicator would require additional episode-level data that are not currently available.

Therefore, the app is appropriate for Sophie's initial discovery and screening task, but not for evaluating final partnership suitability. Given the available data, the existing screening functionality and clearly stated limitations provide a useful starting point for her research without introducing an unreliable guest-interview measure.